

Group Observation

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Group Observation Part 1

Town Council Meeting

A town council meeting can be identified as a task group, which is designed to complete a specific function or accomplish goals that serve an external purpose rather than focusing inward on members' growth or well-being. The expected purpose of the town council meeting is to address community issues through formal discussions, make policy decisions which impact the town's residents, and allocate resources in a way that best supports the community and its needs. The intended goals, therefore, would likely be to maintain transparency and efficiency while representing the concerns of the community. The population that benefits from this group is the town's residents, who rely on the council to address issues such as infrastructure, safety, budgeting, and local ordinances. The council itself serves as a representative body for the larger community, making its function more formal than many other types of groups.

Personal Biases

One personal bias I bring to this observation is my assumption that town council meetings are often dull, overly procedural, and less engaging than treatment-oriented or community-based groups can be. While I enjoy politics and the processes involved, I recognize that they often involve conflict and inefficiencies. This could lead me to focus more on whatever conflict is present rather than the collaborative efforts of those involved. Another potential bias comes from my interest in social justice and systemic change. I may be more critical of decisions which maintain the status quo or that I feel don't adequately address inequalities in the community. To address these biases, I will have to ruminate on all the details presented, with the reminder to be intentional and focused on maintaining mental balance, rather than focusing on

any one aspect over another. I will also keep mindfulness than mundaneness and inefficiency do not inherently mean dysfunction.

Expectations

I can imagine that the group would follow a structured agenda. Task groups such as council meetings often use formal procedures to guide discussion and ensure fairness. I anticipate that the meeting will begin with routine business, move into reports or updates, and then shift into decision-making on current issues. The rationale for this expectation comes from the need for order in governance settings. A clear agenda ensures that each topic receives attention and prevents the meeting from becoming unproductive.

A second expectation is that there will be disagreement or debate among council members. Because council members represent different constituencies and perspectives, it is natural for conflict to arise when discussing policy or resource allocation. I anticipate moments of tension, especially if the topic relates to budget priorities or controversial issues in the community. My rationale for this expectation comes from the idea that conflict is a normal part of task group decision-making and can even strengthen outcomes when managed effectively.

My third expectation is that a leader or facilitator, such as the mayor or a designated chairperson, will play a strong role in guiding the meeting. This person will likely manage the flow of discussion, recognize speakers, and keep the meeting on schedule. The rationale is that task groups require leadership to remain efficient and to ensure that decisions are reached in a timely manner. Without clear leadership, the council would risk becoming disorganized or failing to complete its agenda.

DBT Session

Conversely, a Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT) Session is a treatment group, which is designed to promote personal change, provide support, and build coping skills among participants. Unlike task groups, which focus on accomplishing external objectives, treatment groups concentrate on the internal growth and development of members. The purpose of a DBT group is usually to teach participants skills for emotional regulation, distress tolerance, and interpersonal effectiveness. The group's goals are to help individuals improve their ability to manage strong emotions, reduce self-destructive behaviors, and enhance their relationships. The population served typically includes individuals who experience mental health challenges such as borderline personality disorder, anxiety, depression, or difficulty managing intense emotions. The group setting provides participants with both professional guidance and peer support, offering a unique therapeutic environment.

Personal Biases

While DBT groups can be emotionally charged, they also include structured skill-building and teaching, which I may unintentionally minimize if I focus too much on the emotional elements. Because I strongly value therapy, I may be inclined to view the group too positively, assuming that all participants will benefit equally, or even at all. This bias could lead me to overlook challenges, such as participant disengagement or difficulty applying skills. To address these biases, I will remind myself to observe with neutrality and to look for both strengths and limitations in the group. I will also take note of the facilitator's strategies and the participants' responses, rather than focusing solely on either emotions or successes.

Expectations

One expectation I have is that the facilitator will begin the session by reviewing group rules, clarifying expectations, or providing an outline of the day's topic. In treatment groups, particularly DBT, structure is essential for creating a safe environment and keeping members focused on therapeutic goals. Usually, participants are more likely to feel comfortable and engaged when they know what to expect.

A second expectation is that group members will share personal experiences or challenges related to the skills being taught. For example, participants may discuss how they applied a DBT strategy in a real-life situation, or reflect on difficulties they encountered. DBT emphasizes practical application, and sharing experiences allows members to learn from one another while practicing vulnerability in a supportive environment.

A third expectation is that group members will validate and encourage one another during the session. Peer support is a vital component of treatment groups, and validation helps participants feel heard and understood. I anticipate that the facilitator will also model validation and encourage members to respond positively to each other. This assumption is because supportive interactions build trust and contribute to the therapeutic process, making it easier for individuals to adopt and practice new skills.

Group Observation Part 2: Group Analyses

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Group Observation Part 2: Group Analyses

The first observed group was a formal municipal decision-making body composed of the town council, the mayor—and later the mayor pro tem, planning staff, and the development team presenting the Green Park Inn rezoning request. The meeting followed a strictly hierarchical and agenda-driven structure, consistent with local government procedures. The mayor initially facilitated the meeting, but later recused himself and delegated leadership to the mayor pro tem in his stead. Council members served as voting participants, planning staff provided technical and zoning expertise, and the developers functioned as invited presenters, addressing questions. This structure clearly distinguished between decision makers, experts, and stakeholders, and procedural norms were closely followed. This formal structure supported transparency and ensured that the rezoning request was addressed in an organized, legally compliant manner.

Group Dynamics

Group dynamics were shaped by both the complexity of the situation and the emotional significance of the historic Green Park Inn. Council members consistently expressed a desire for certainty regarding restoration or reconstruction feasibility, while the developers emphasized the presence of many unknown structural factors that could hinder or alter the plan. This tension produced a dynamic where discussion frequently returned to feasibility, the condition of original materials, and whether the project would ultimately be a restoration or a replica, based on the viability of the original materials.

Leadership

Leadership was primarily held by the mayor, and later the mayor pro tem, who guided the flow of discussion, enforced procedure, and managed the agenda. Leadership was also indirectly

shared as the developers were given space to present expertise on engineering, construction, and historic materials. Planning staff contributed technical leadership by explaining zoning constraints and how conditional zoning could or could not accommodate the proposal. The overall group dynamic followed predictable phases of present information, then open the floor for questions, and finally move to the next structured point and repeat until the discussion was complete, which helped keep the discussion relatively structured, despite its complexity.

Expectations

Before watching the meeting, I expected a more linear presentation followed by brief clarifying questions. Instead, the discussion was far more iterative and somewhat emotionally charged, largely because of the historic nature of the building and the level of uncertainty involved. The council repeatedly asked for clarity that the developers could not fully provide due to unknown structural conditions. This contradicted my expectation that the developers would have most details finalized before presenting, but it also makes sense given the request for investment. I also expected the meeting to stay focused on the rezoning item for either way less time, or the whole time, but after the vote and a brief break, the group shifted to other, unrelated topics, including the Memorial Park advisory committee's report, projected renovation costs, and crosswalk visibility issues. I did not anticipate how many separate topics the one meeting would cover in the relatively brief time that was left.

Theoretical Framework

The meeting can best be understood using Systems Theory, as multiple interconnected systems such as historic preservation requirements, municipal zoning regulations, construction limitations, financial constraints, and community expectations, shaped how the group interacted.

Each subsystem influenced the others; for example, the deteriorating condition of the structure produced uncertainty, which affected the council's decision making.

Change Approach

The group appeared to operate using a Solution-Focused change approach. Much of the discussion centered on what could be done rather than focusing solely on barriers. The developers framed their responses around possible pathways, including hand demolition, phased construction, and using as much original material as feasible, and council members asked solution-oriented questions such as what degree of certainty would allow the project to move forward. The effectiveness of solution-focused practice was limited by the many unresolved unknowns. However, despite having incomplete information, the group's "yes" vote reflected movement toward a specific and future-oriented plan, which solution-focused work typically relies on. This also illustrates how solution-focused work emphasizes progress over perfect clarity, as waiting for more information can sometimes serve to hinder the solution process.

Group 2: DBT

The Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT) group operated as a structured treatment group facilitated by a therapist who maintained clear boundaries while fostering a supportive and collaborative environment. The session began with the therapist introducing herself and reiterating the confidentiality agreement and paperwork participants had previously signed. This reinforced ethical practice and established psychological safety. The session followed a structured, goal-oriented format: introductions and icebreaker, explanation of group purpose, a grounding activity, a brief psychoeducational lesson, and an emotional regulation exercise. Leadership was centralized but participatory, with the therapist guiding and modeling activities while also engaging as a member, which reduced power imbalance and promoted trust.

Dynamics

The group's dynamics were relaxed, supportive, and interactive. The icebreaker activity: "Two Truths and a Lie" helped participants get comfortable with one another while also humanizing the therapist, as she participated equally. This exercise fostered group cohesion by breaking down barriers and encouraging openness. As the session progressed, the therapist facilitated mindful grounding through sensory-based exercises, guiding each member to describe an object without naming it. This helped anchor participants in the present moment and introduced mindfulness concepts in an accessible way. The transition from casual to therapeutic discussion was seamless, maintaining engagement while introducing DBT's skill-building components.

Leadership

Leadership was consistent and adaptive. The therapist demonstrated a balance of authority and empathy by setting expectations and explaining rationales for each activity, while maintaining a calm, validating tone. Her active participation in exercises modeled vulnerability and encouraged shared learning. When explaining DBT concepts such as opposite action and emotion-driven urges, she used concrete examples, then invited members to apply these ideas to their own experiences. This method emphasized both cognitive understanding and emotional application, consistent with experiential learning models in group therapy.

Theoretical Framework

The therapist's use of grounding and opposite action reflected DBT's balance of acceptance and change. From a change approach perspective, the group reflected elements of both Solution-Focused and Cognitive Restructuring practice. Participants were encouraged to identify emotional triggers and generate alternative, more adaptive responses, focusing on what

can be done rather than on problems. This approach empowered members to take small, actionable steps toward emotional balance.

Expectations

When compared to my initial expectations, the group closely aligned with what I anticipated, but I was also met with some surprises. As expected, the facilitator opened by reviewing rules and clarifying confidentiality, which created a sense of structure and safety. My expectation that the group would involve both instruction and personal sharing was also met, with members describing their current emotions and potential reactions in a circular discussion that encouraged vulnerability and reflection. Additionally, the validation and encouragement I expected were clearly present, both from the therapist and among group members. However, I had anticipated a more emotionally charged atmosphere, and instead observed a calmer, more skills-focused environment. The therapist's approach kept discussion grounded in learning rather than emotional intensity.

References

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